







"Jal Sanchay Jan Bhagidari"

THE WARRIORS OF MODI'S WATER MISSION

Prime Minister Narendra Modi's vision for a water-secure India is being realized through bold reforms, conservation initiatives, and grassroots leadership. While initiatives such as Jal Jeevan Mission, Jal Shakti Abhiyan: Catch The Rain, Namami Gange, and Atal Bhujal Yojana are transforming water access, quality, and management, this water renaissance thrives on its silent soldiers who battle scarcity with resolve. As water warriors, some of whom were recognized with the National Water Awards, these custodians of a precious resource are proving that Jal Samridh Bharat is not just a dream but a movement.

■ **By A Special Correspondent** ■

Water is India's oldest storyteller. It has shaped civilizations, nurtured livelihoods, and dictated fates. Yet today, it stands at crossroads—with problems of pollution and over extraction. The challenge is immense: a country with 18 per cent of the world's population has access to just 4 per cent of global freshwater. The solution? A seismic shift in how India values and manages water. That shift is happening now. Under Prime Minister Narendra Modi's leadership, India is rewriting its water story—one tap, one river, one village at a time. The vision is bold: Amrit Kaal Viksit Bharat 2047, a future where water is not a crisis but a promise.

The answer to India's water woes is surprisingly simple: Reduce, Reuse, Recharge, Recycle. Every drop matters and this philosophy drives every water mission in the country today. "These guiding principles of Prime Minister Modi determine the demand-side interventions of our ministry. It's about making rainwater work for us, turning wastewater into an asset, and changing habits so that conservation becomes second nature," says C. R. Patil, Union Minister of Jal Shakti.

For millions of Indian women, fetching water was once an exhausting daily ritual—long hours spent walking to wells, balancing heavy pots, and waiting in endless lines. This changed in 2019 with the launch of the **Jal Jeevan Mission** (JJM), which set out to provide every rural household with a functional tap connection, ensuring 55 litres of clean water per person per day.

The impact has been remarkable. Rural tap water coverage has surged from just 16 per cent in 2019 to 80 per cent today. Eight states and three Union Territories have achieved 100 per cent tap water access. More than 1.45 lakh villages have been declared 'Har Ghar Jal,' and 9 crore women have been freed from the drudgery of water-fetching, allowing them to engage in more productive activities.

Access to safe drinking water has had profound health and economic benefits. A meta-analysis by Nobel laureate Professor Michael Kremer suggests that it can reduce infant mortality by 30 per cent. The World Health Organization estimates that India could prevent 4 lakh